What It Means to be 'Mexican': A Persona-based Semantics Account of an Unexpected Slur

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1. Introduction

1.1 An unexpected meaning for 'Mexican'

Mexican has been used as a derogatory term in the United States since at least the middle of the 20th century (Silver City 2011), yet no linguistic accounts exist which analyse the term as a pejorative. However, recent events have brought the word into national media and the public sphere in ways it was not before. The slurish nature of the word can be found in several recent reports, including the running of a news chyron which claimed that the Latin American countries of Honduras, Guatemala, and El Salvador are 'Mexican countries.' The text, which showed briefly across the bottom of a national television news broadcast in March 2019, read, 'Trump cuts U.S. aid to 3 Mexican countries,' and inspired strong reactions across social media and traditional outlets (Lafrance 2019, Stelter 2019)[1].

Some commentators regarded the slipup as a sleep-deprivation-induced mistake, while others saw it as an indication of an ideology commonly held with respect to Hispanics, and

[1] There are two possible broad interpretations of the meaning of this phrase, the first being that Mexico is a region within which these countries are situated, and the second being that *Mexican* here is being used to describe the countries qualitatively, rather than geographically. The most plausible account, a priori, is that both of these are pertinent to the meaning communicated here, and are not necessarily distinct in the ideology associated with this use of the word. My thanks to Toni Bassaganyas Bars for discussion on this point.

especially Hispanic immigrants, in the United States. This analysis is in line with other public uses of the term *Mexican* in ways that have led to lawsuits, public apologies, Internet outrage, and extensive media coverage (see, for example, Associated Press 1997; Boyd 2011, Fox News 2011, Silver City 2011; Manchester n.d., PBS 2016, Stracqualursi and Struyk 2017, Wolf 2018, Wehner 2019). One use of the term by US President Donald Trump caused him to attempt to immediately rescind whatever negative connotation his use of the term introduced (as quoted in Manchester n.d.):

(1) The judge, who happens to be, we believe, Mexican, which is great, I think that's fine.

Another instance of *Mexican* being used in a manner that drew public outrage is cited in a local newspaper from Grant County, New Mexico. State Representative Sheryl Williams Stapleton used the term to refer to then-governor Susana Martinez during an argument with another lawmaker (Silver City 2011) – the action resulted in a public apology and calls for the congresswoman to step down from her leadership role in the New Mexico House (Boyd 2011):

(2) [You're] carrying the Mexican's water on the fourth floor.

The case of *Mexican* is complicated by the fact that the same term is also used as a demonym and as a reference to someone of Mexican ancestry. One dictionary gives the definitions of *Mexican* as 'a native or inhabitant of Mexico,' or 'a person of Mexican descent'[2] (Merriam-Webster 2019a). Though these meanings – a person originating from or living in

[2] A third definition is given for the southwestern US: "a person of mixed Spanish and Indian descent." This meaning, however, does not appear to have reached wide recognition or use.

Mexico, or a person descended from others for whom this was or is the case – are some of the meanings the term carries, they are not the whole picture. At the most basic, we can divide instances of the word into cases where it speaks to the (direct or indirect) national origin of an individual on the one hand, and cases where it is used to denigrate individuals who may or may not have any personal or lineal connection to Mexico, on the other. As we will see, this range of meaning poses a challenge to traditional analyses of slurs.[3]

Other racial slurs, such as *chink*, *nigger* (Hom 2008); *jap*, *coon*, and *cracker* and non-racial slurs such as *dyke* (Burnett 2019a), *fag*, *kike*, and *bitch* (Anderson and Lepore 2013) have specific forms that differentiate them from what may be considered their 'neutral'[4] counterparts (in these cases, *Chinese person*, *African American*, *Japanese person*, *Black person*, (*poor) White person*, *lesbian*, *homosexual person*, *Jewish*, and *woman*, respectively). Each of these obviously derogatory terms has a counterpart that is typically used to refer to another person without slurring them. *Mexican* has, as a potential counterpart in this sense, the word *beaner* (Romero 2019), which may be used to communicate what, following Hom (2008), would be something like 'from Mexico and despicable because of it.' However, the term *Mexican* itself is also capable of communicating content that calls for classifying the word as a slur, but is not always used towards those with some sort of connection to Mexico. In fact, *Mexican* appears to make reference to different groups of people when it is used to slur compared to when it is not.

[3] The implications for analyses of demonyms and heritage terms are also interesting, but, though these uses of the word are discussed in comparison to the slurring use, analysis of the word as a demonym and as a heritage term is not the focus of this paper.

[4] The term 'neutral' would suggest that these terms carry no social or ideological weight, and can be used as purely referential lexical items, which seems unlikely; but it remains that each of these obviously derogatory terms has a counterpart that is usually used to refer to another person without slurring them. In this paper, it is treated as a heuristic for discussing what are usually seen as non-derogatory correlates of slurs.

The uses of the word *Mexican* call for close consideration of the various aspects of its meaning in different contexts of use.[5] This paper will argue that the word *Mexican* holds semantic and social meanings that make it resistant to analysis using traditional approaches to slurs, yet must be considered to be a (semi-)slur based on its available uses. A new analysis is proposed which makes use of recent work in semantics, sociolinguistics, and at the socio-semantics interface. First, a review of other approaches to slurs is given. Then, building on Burnett (2019a), an analysis of *Mexican* is proposed which uses conceptual semantics (Gärdenfors 2000, 2014) and the notion of personae (Coupland 2007, Eckert 2019a); this is combined with Social Meaning Games (Burnett 2019b) to more fully explicate the interpretation of the word *Mexican* in interaction, taking into consideration various linguistic and situational factors, and interlocutors' reasoning involving these.

2. Representations of Slurred Meaning

2.1 'Mexican' as a demonym and as a slur

Perhaps the most readily identifiable broad interpretation of the word *Mexican* is as a gentilic: a word that classifies a particular person as part of a group based on their ethnic or national affiliation. These words – which include items such as *Mexican*, *Jamaican*, *Vietnamese*, and *Spaniard* – pick out members of groups and may simultaneously assign certain characteristics assumed (but not entailed) of a person in that group, such as race, cultural values, style of dress, or attitude; it seems reasonable to expect that greater familiarity with a group will lead to more robust meanings associated with the corresponding gentilic. Some gentilics are

[5] Other considerations, such as information structure and prosody, are also likely to play important roles. For example, Sendlmeier et al. (2016) show that prosody alone – specifically lower pitch, less pitch variation, slower rate of speech, and syllable prolongation to mark syllable stress – can communicate negative attitude when the semantic content of a phrase is ambiguous as to the attitude of the speaker. This is not taken up in this paper, but is an important direction for future work.

available as both nouns and adjectives (*Mexican, Jamaican*), while others are only found as adjectives in their most 'neutral' sense (cf. the negative connotation or outright ungrammaticality of the phrase, 'a Vietnamese'); still others are found only as nouns (*Spaniard*).

Whatever connotations may be associated with *Mexican* when used to pick out a person in a non-derogatory way, it has two principal uses; here the overarching categorization as a gentilic is divided using more fine-grained distinctions. The first use refers to someone who lives in or was born in Mexico – I employ 'Mexican as demonym,' or $Mexican_D$, in referring to this use. Second, in the United States, words which identify a person's national origin are also commonly employed to reference heritage, even after several generations have intervened since the family line took root in the US. One woman, when asked about her origin, replied, "I'm Mexican," and explains that she belongs to the fourth generation of her family in the United States (Time 2016). I refer to this use as 'Mexican by heritage,' or $Mexican_H$. When used to communicate $Mexican_D$ or $Mexican_H$, as well as the third meaning described below, *Mexican* can be used nominally and adjectivally[6].

As a noun or as an adjective (see (1) and (2), respectively, above), *Mexican* may also be used to communicate a derogatory attitude in a way that is not necessarily consistent with its use as a demonym or in reference to a person's heritage. The three uses of the term are not truth-conditionally or referentially equivalent, and represent distinct yet partially overlapping sets. When used as a slur, the target of the slur need not have any personal or familial connection to Mexico. Along with applying to persons who are not, in fact, Mexican (in the usual sense), this use of the word – '*Mexican* as slur' ($Mexican_S$) – communicates negative evaluation of the target of its use. As an example, a Honduran woman or Venezuelan man may

[6] Though fine – and important – differences are certain to exist between them, here we are concerned with both the nominal and adjectival as expressions of objects represented in the language ideologies of speakers. As such, they will not be differentiated between herein.

be referred to as *Mexican*, employing the term's $Mexican_S$ use, but not the $Mexican_D$ or $Mexican_H$ uses; that is, *Mexican* can be used to slur someone who is not Mexican, but it cannot felicitously be used to refer in a more 'neutral' way to someone who is not Mexican. The derogatory content, which is sometimes identified as a derogatory attitude of the speaker, specifically, is the foundation of slurs (see Hom 2008, Anderson and Lepore 2013, Burnett 2019a). In approaches to slurs found in the literature, they are also assumed to have a neutral counterpart; be used to denigrate a class of people, not only the individual who is the target of slurring; vary in force; act in the absence of intention on the part of the speaker to derogate; be subject to strict social constraints; have a force that may evolve over time; often escape the scope ('scope out') of semantic contexts that typically constrain other types of meanings; and be available for appropriation by members of the target group (Hom 2008, Anderson and Lepore 2013, Jeshion 2013, Burnett 2019a).

When compared with canonical slurs, and analyses of them, *Mexican* shows slurish behaviour – it cannot be used to denigrate an individual without also denigrating a class of people simultaneously; it can derogate in the absence of a speaker's intention; it is subject to strict social regulation; it seems to be evolving in force; and it scopes out of usually constraining semantic operators. However, *Mexican* has a complex relationship with these and other criteria for slurs. Specifically, I will focus on the behaviour of *Mexican* as it relates to four characteristics commonly associated with slurs: the status of its derogatory meaning when used in different linguistic and social contexts; its availability for appropriation; the nature of the relationship between its offense-causing potential and the intentions of the person using it; and whether or not it can be said to have a 'neutral' counterpart.

2.2 'Mexican' and semantic operators

The expressivist account of meaning has been applied to slurs by several authors (Schlenker 2007, McCready 2010, Jeshion 2013, among others). The expressivist stance holds that derogatory content as part of slurs is attached to the at-issue content of the slur, but is not the same as that content (see Potts 2007 for an analysis of the expressivist approach more generally). Depending on the particular analysis, this meaning is held to be of its own class of expressive content (Potts 2007); to be presuppositional (Schlenker 2007); or to be conventionally implicated (McCready 2010).

An example of the usefulness of expressivism to account for slurs is found in Burnett (2019a). The classic 'holes' for presupposition are negation, modals, the antecedents of conditionals, and interrogatives (Potts 2015); these are the operators out from under which presuppositions are meant to project their meaning. In her discussion of *dyke*, a slur sometimes used against lesbians, Burnett (2019a) shows that that word, in some cases, fits the idea of derogatory attitude as presupposition. She gives the following examples, along with her *Dude, not cool!* test, whereby a reaction of *Dude, not cool!* of an in-group member to out-group use of a term indicates the presence of a derogatory attitude attributed to the speaker (adapted from Burnett 2019a:5):

(3) a. Sarah is a dyke. *Dude, not cool!*

b. Sarah is not a dyke. *Dude, not cool!*

c. If Sarah is a dyke, then she'll know when the Pride parade is. *Dude, not cool!*

d. Is Sarah a dyke? *Dude, not cool!*

Burnett evaluates the instances of the use of *dyke* (by an out-group member) in (3a-d) as all communicating derogatory attitude; that is, this attitude behaves like a presupposition by projecting out of these environments and being attributed to the speaker. A similar analysis would apply to a wide variety of slurs. Potts (2007:170) offers an example in which the expressive content does not behave like a presupposition, as it does not respond to the presupposition plug *believe* (Potts 2015), as evidenced by the infelicity (indicated by #) of the continuation in parentheses:

(4) Sue believes that that bastard Kresge should be fired. (#I think he's a good guy.)

On Potts' account, the negative content associated with *bastard* is even more strongly projecting than a presupposition would be, and he proposes that this is a different type of content from presupposition.

On either assumption of expressive content, one meaning of *Mexican*, *Mexican*$_S$, shows the same behaviour as other slurs. Under semantic holes, the derogatory content projects, as in (5); under plugs, the content also projects, as in (6):

(5) a. You're carrying the water for the Mexican on the fourth floor. *Dude, not cool!*

b. You're not carrying the water for the Mexican
on the fourth floor. *Dude, not cool!*

c. If you're carrying the water for the Mexican on the fourth
floor, you must be her assistant. *Dude, not cool!*

d. Are you carrying the water for the Mexican on the fourth floor? *Dude, not cool!*

(6) Sue believes that that Mexican Kresge should be fired. (#I think he's a good guy.)

Note that the target of the utterance in (5a), as reported in Boyd (2011), Fox News (2011), and Silver City (2011) was a woman of Mexican heritage; that is, she could be referred to as *Mexican*$_H$. Crucially, arriving at these judgements requires specific contexts of use; but an instance of *Mexican* (*Mexican*$_S$) as a slur will be interpreted as slurish regardless of the semantic operators under whose scope it falls. However, it is this need to arrive at a specific meaning of *Mexican* that precludes treating the word as containing expressive content, whether this content be treated as a conventional implicature, a presupposition, or a different type of expressive content, which should be present wherever the word is used. It has been noted that the expressivist approach does not account for a particularly common aspect of slurs: that of non-derogatory appropriated use, that is, use by members of the target group which does not denigrate; Burnett (2019a) shows that when appropriated use is brought under consideration, the expressivist approach no longer suffices for *dyke*. Aside from the issue of appropriation (dealt with below), this problem is even larger for *Mexican*, as non-appropriated, non-derogatory uses are much more common and less constrained than with other slurs.

Before leaving the discussion of implicatures, one more consideration is in order. From a strictly pragmatic perspective, it is tempting, at first glance, to assume that some uses of *Mexican* may produce a conversational implicature (Grice 1975, Levinson 1983, Huang 2014) which then must be resolved by attributing to the speaker a negative attitude toward the referent. As discussed in a footnote by Hom, conversational implicature is not adequate to account for the meanings of slurs (2008:434); for the case of *Mexican*, specifically, we can look again at (1), repeated here as (7):

(7) The judge, who happens to be, we believe, Mexican, which is great, I think that's fine.

The speaker appears to recognize a negative connotation attached to his use of the term in discussing the judge's heritage, and attempts to reverse it. However, he is unsuccessful in his attempt (as evidenced by the response in the media), because this meaning associated with *Mexican* is uncancellable, therefore ruling out conversational implicature as a viable explanation. In this instance, the speaker is questioning the impartiality of the judge to handle a court case in which the speaker is a defendant; however, the meaning associated with this use of the term goes beyond the link he is suggesting between loyalty to Mexico, and, therefore, an inability on the judge's part to handle the case without bias: the remarks were called "the textbook definition of a racist comment" by a prominent member of his own political party (PBS 2016). In section 3.3, we return to this particular case, and it is shown that, for this speaker, it is unlikely that any use he makes of the word *Mexican* will result in an interpretation of the term as anything other than $Mexican_S$.

2.3 Appropriation of 'Mexican'

Mexican is not a clear case when it comes to appropriation. Appropriation refers to the use of a slur by members of the target group for reference to other members of the group in a way that does not denigrate; a prominent example is the wide-spread use of the n-word in African American culture, with multiple at-issue meanings attached to it (Kennedy 1999, Jones and Hall to appear). The issues regarding appropriation of the term stem from its distinct meanings: the word itself can be used by anyone, depending on contextual factors; therefore, it is not obviously available for appropriation. In this way, *Mexican* is like *lesbian* as discussed in Burnett (2019a).

Burnett considers *dyke* and *lesbian* together, and mentions that for some speakers, *lesbian* is in fact something of a vulgar term. In what she identifies as the bigot ideology, there are negative associations not only with *dyke* (normally the counterpart of *lesbian* subjected to the same restrictions as other slurs) but with the term traditionally considered 'neutral' as well: she mentions the case of Emma Gonzalez, a Parkland school shooting survivor who became an activist for gun control. Gonzalez was singled out by Leslie Gibson, a candidate (at the time) for the Maine House of Representatives, as being a 'skinhead lesbian.' The comment was seen by some as an "attack on her sexual orientation," and eventually resulted in the candidate withdrawing from the race (Brammer 2018; Stevens 2018). This highlights the behaviour of a word which is not subject to strict non-usage restrictions for parts of the population, and is therefore not readily appropriated.

Some important comparisons are in order here. *Mexican* is like *lesbian* in that it is sometimes used as a slur, though not always, but it differs from *lesbian* in that *lesbian* is not used to slur someone who is not, in fact, a homosexual woman. This speaks to the availability of a term for slurring in the first place. Burnett (2019a) points out that *dyke* is what could be seen as the slurish counterpart to *lesbian*; however, though this is not discussed by Burnett, it seems unlikely that someone would attempt to slur someone who is *not* a homosexual woman with the word *lesbian*; instead, they would use *dyke* to refer to someone they knew was not homosexual, yet exhibited salient characteristics associated with the personae represented by *dyke* in various speakers' ideologies. I return to the case of *lesbian* and *dyke* in sections 3.1 and 3.2 below.

Though an exhaustive listing of what constitutes a slur has not, to my knowledge, been undertaken, it seems clear that appropriation is neither a necessary nor sufficient condition for slurs; one could hardly imagine, for example, members of the Japanese American community

in the middle of the 20th century referring to one another as *jap*; on the other hand, someone could reasonably appropriate a derogatory term that is not a slur, such as *fatso* (Jeshion 2013:235). *Mexican*, then, not apparently available for appropriation, is like some other slurs in this way.

2.4 The derogatory (non)autonomy of 'Mexican'

Offensive autonomy (Burnett 2019a) refers to the ability of a word to derogate in the absence of the speaker's intention to do so. For some slurs, such as the n-word, their use virtually always communicates this attitude on the part of the speaker, except for in appropriated or other specifically non-derogatory contexts. Hom notes that when a racist term is used in order to address its derogatory content, the sentence in which it is carried is interpreted as being "meaningful, true, and nonderogatory" (2008:429). Using the word *chink*, which is sometimes employed to slur people with Chinese heritage, Hom gives the example found in (8). In such situations, the hearer is likely to understand that the speaker is not using *chink* to derogate, given that they are specifically calling attention to the people who would use it in such a way:

(8) Racists believe that Chinese people are chinks.

The case of *Mexican* is different. Other slurs are distinguished, in part, by their offensive autonomy, which *Mexican* also seems to show under certain circumstances; but, unlike other slurs, the intention to derogate seems to be used by listeners in determining whether *Mexican* has been employed as a slur in the first place. Linguistic context seems to play a role; the head coach of a team in the National Basketball Association (NBA) using (9) to refer to a reporter

resulted in a lawsuit and a $25,000 fine from the league (Associated Press 1997; Reporters Committee 1997):

(9) You fucking Mexican idiot.

The (non-Hispanic, white) coach's comments were likely interpreted using multiple clues to which meaning of *Mexican* he was employing; but it seems reasonable to say that the words surrounding the slur influenced interpretation. How this and similar considerations enter into the model developed in this paper is discussed later.

Compared to other gentilics used in the same context, we see that *Mexican* here contributes something to the meaning of the utterance beyond something like 'negative attitude toward the target'; it's also clear that *Mexican* contributes something definite, whereas other options are ambiguous at best. Though the listener may try to understand how exactly *Swedish* and *idiot* are to be interpreted together, once a negative meaning for *Mexican* is ascertained, the nature of the negativity becomes clear:

(10) a. You fucking Mexican idiot.
b. You fucking American idiot.
c. You fucking Swedish idiot.

Removing this linguistic context, we can examine some hypothetical uses of different gentilics to see what meanings they might contribute:

(11) a. You Mexican.

b. You Canadian.

c. You Brazilian.

Here, the meaning employed for *Mexican* is less clear – but the other two terms either contribute something that may actually be positive for the vast majority of American English speakers (*Canadian*) or ambiguous as to the meaning it is meant to communicate (*Brazilian*).

Whereas uses of slurs such as *chink*, *dyke*, or *fag* seem to communicate derogatory content with or without a speaker's intent to do so, the use of *Mexican* is interpreted with this intent in mind. As well will see in section 3, the interpretation of the intent of a speaker is co-occurrent with the interpretation of the meaning of the word.

2.5 A 'neutral' counterpart for 'Mexican'

In most approaches to slurs, a slur's 'neutral' counterpart is taken to contribute its truth-conditional or at-issue meaning to the slur. Hom (2008:431) gives the content of a slur using the formal expression in (12) (see also Burnett 2019a:10):

(12) *ought to be subject to* $p^*_1 + \ldots + p^*_n$ *because of being* $d^*_1 + \ldots + d^*_n$ *all because of being NPC**, where $p^*_1, \ldots, p^*_n$ are deontic prescriptions derived from the set of racist practices, $d^*_1, \ldots, d^*_n$ are the negative properties derived from the racist ideology, and NPC* is the semantic value of the appropriate nonpejorative correlate of the epithet.

Hom's *combinatorial externalism* views racist slurs as expressing "complex, socially constructed, negative properties" which are determined based on an "external, causal connection with racist institutions" (2008:431). The social and external nature of the

determinants of the derogatory content of slurs seem accurate, and will be discussed in section 3.2; but the important thing to note here is that this definition of slurs depends on there being correlated, non-pejorative terms associated with them. This does not seem to be an accurate assumption when it comes to *Mexican*.

The first thing to consider is whether *Mexican* can be seen as two words in the lexicon; that is, as homophonous predicates, which are slurish and non-slur counterparts. A similar suggestion has been made for derogatory and non-derogatory uses of other slurs, but has been shown to lead to the *appropriation worry*, as explained by Burnett (2019a:7-8): "if there exists a separate non-derogatory predicate, then why can't 'out group' members use it?" This might be expressed as a broader *homophony worry*: if there exist multiple predicates, some derogatory and some not, then why can a speaker not freely choose to use one or other of them, and claim they were using a non-derogatory word when their comments spark indignation?

The other most likely contenders as alternative terms for *Mexican* as a slur in the US are *Hispanic* and *Latino*. First, it is important to consider the meanings that the latter two terms are taken to have. Arreola (2004) discusses the patterns of use of the two terms for self-identification, as investigated by an analysis of use in newspapers from major US cities in 1989-1990 and by voter polling done in 2000. Arreola reports that the count of the terms in newspapers found that *Hispanic* was much preferred in most publications reviewed, with the notable exception of the *Los Angeles Times*, whereas of 1,200 Hispanic/Latino voters in the year 2000, 65% had a preference for *Hispanic* and 30% preferred *Latino*. However people of Latin American descent choose to identify, it is important to note that the two words are treated as being interchangeable by these investigations into their usage. This is reinforced by dictionary entries showing that both may be used to refer to people of Latin American heritage (Merriam-Webster

2019b, 2019c). If these are used to refer to the same group of people, and in a similar way, can they both also be said to be the neutral counterparts of *Mexican* as a racial slur?

For this to be the case, it needs to be shown that the meaning of *Mexican* is related to the meaning of *Hispanic/Latino*[7] in such a way that *Mexican* means *Hispanic/Latino*, but with the addition of negative content. When considering $Mexican_S$ alone, *Hispanic/Latino* does appear to be the 'neutral' counterpart of the word, as discussed below. However, the non-slur usages of $Mexican_D$ and $Mexican_H$ cause this neat correlation to break down, since in these cases *Mexican* is a proper subset of *Hispanic/Latino*, and can therefore not be coextensive with it. So what does it mean to be *Mexican*?

2.6 'Mexican' as a racialized stereotype

Several recent news reports show that for some who live in the United States, there is a blurring of the differentiation between Mexicans on the one hand and Hispanics and Latinos more generally on the other. Further, those who do not apparently consider these terms to be interchangeable – that is, those who acknowledge a difference between *Hispanic/Latino* and *Mexican* – are still able to interpret the use of the latter in referring to the former. Example (9), repeated here as (13), was uttered by the speaker as a verbal attack on a Mexican American reporter. It isn't clear whether the speaker knew for certain that his target had Mexican heritage; what is clear is his organization's response to the incident, which claimed that the team "deplores any racial or ethnic remarks by any member of the organization or by anyone else" (Associated Press 1997).

[7] These will be considered as one term in this paper, given their general interchangeability, as outlined above. This is not to suggest, however, that there are no important differences between them.

(13) You fucking Mexican idiot.

This remark was seen to be a racial slur (Roberts 1997) – not a slur regarding the target's national origin or family history – in the press and within the organization that employed the person who used it. That *Hispanic/Latino* are understood to fit under the heading *Mexican* for some speakers is also evidenced in news reports in the wake of a mass shooting in El Paso, Texas in August 2019 (Anguiano 2019; Fernández Campbell 2019; Levin 2019). Dan Anguiano points out that there was fear on the part of Latinos across the country after the event, though the shooter's manifesto claimed to target "as many Mexicans as possible;" Sam Levin reported the words of the El Paso sheriff, who said that "[t]his Anglo man came here to kill Hispanics," and called the attack the work of a "racist" who went to the city to kill people because of "the color of their skin." In a separate, non-violent incident a month before, two women were video recorded telling the manager of a restaurant, who was speaking Spanish with an employee, to "[g]o back to Mexico if you want to keep speaking Spanish.... Go back to your Mexican country" (Anguiano 2019, Pitman 2019); the man informed the women that he was of Puerto Rican descent.

It is important to note that the term *Mexican* is, in the language ideologies evidenced in these incidents, narrowly conceived: it focuses not on people of Mexican origin, but on the wider Hispanic/Latino population; however, the term also takes another factor into account, which is the perceived race of the target. That is, for some speakers, *Mexican* denotes neither someone with links to Mexico nor as *Hispanic/Latino* broadly conceived as regarding place of origin; instead, the term is associated with a persona (Coupland 2007, Eckert 2019b), which is in this case a simplified and stereotyped version of a Hispanic/Latino person, which takes into account, especially, traditional markers of race (e.g. skin colour) and native language. The

concept of personae is looked at in more depth below, and in sections 3.2 and 3.3, we will see how personae are an integral part of modelling the different interpretations of the word *Mexican*.

3. A New Approach: Conceptual Spaces with Personae

3.1 The role of personae in the interpretation of linguistic behaviour

The concept of personae has become very influential in the sociolinguistic literature in recent years (e.g. Zhang 2005, Coupland 2007, Campbell-Kibler 2008, D'Onofrio 2015, Eckert 2019a), and has been investigated both as identity constructed in interaction (see, e.g., Eckert 2000, Bucholtz 2001, Podesva 2007) and as a factor in listeners' interpretations of communicative behaviour (Campbell-Kibler 2008, D'Onofrio 2015, 2018, among others). Penelope Eckert (2019b:3) defines a persona as a "self-presentation that takes on meaning in, and with respect to, the social-semiotic landscape;" elsewhere, she summarizes the way in which personae are composed: "Sociolinguistic variables combine into speech styles, and these styles in turn combine with other semiotic systems (e.g. clothing, movement, demeanour) in the construction of personae" (Eckert 2019a:4). Rob Voigt and colleagues investigate the relationships among embodied resources (e.g. gestures, body position), social factors, and linguistic factors, and find that these aspects of communication combine into 'multimodal Gestalts' (Mondada 2014, cited in Voigt et al. 2016; Voigt et al. 2016) which are meaningful in interaction; regarding the types of resources that can be used for meaningful social communication, Lorenza Mondada (2016) explains that no one type (e.g. language vs embodiment) is prioritized over any other, and that every detail in communication has the potential to be used for social interaction. Many different signals and types of signals which are given off by an interlocutor enter into the dynamic presentation and interpretation of a persona.

Michael Silverstein (2016) discusses two important aspects of the (assumptions made about the) identities of interlocutors in interaction which are relevant to the dynamics of personae. Silverstein first stresses that there is no interaction in which speakers are not interpreted as *being* someone, as "indexing all manner of sociological category-types made relevant" (2016:56). Second, he notes that (2016:57):

> We come to interaction as partially legible social types, recruited, as one says, to role relationality, and we generally enrich legibility over interaction's time course, reinforcing, or, as the case may be, transforming identities in and by how we say what we say.

A speaker does not have an already-identified persona when they enter into an interaction; instead, they are only 'partially legible' to begin with, and the persona they are taken to represent is identified as the interaction progresses.

The last aspect of personae relevant to our investigation of *Mexican* is found in the work of Annette D'Onofrio. D'Onofrio (2015), using eye-tracking and lexical choice methods, found that persona-based information is integrated into early and automatic linguistic processing, and that the processing of personae cannot be separated from that of phonology (see also discussion in Eckert 2016). D'Onofrio (2018) further showed that listeners divide a phonetic continuum differently depending on the persona-based information they receive regarding a speaker, showing that they have expectations of how speakers, assumed to represent specific personae, will produce phonemes, and concluding that it isn't just that speakers "project these holistic personae in interaction," but rather, "listeners also draw upon these constructs in interpreting the speech of others" (2018:532).

The case of *Mexican* suggests that this persona-based interpretation of the speech of others goes beyond the phonological level of processing and enters into the interpretation of semantic meaning. Building on a model introduced in Burnett (2019a) to account for the slur *dyke*, I propose an account of the meanings and uses of *Mexican* using the conceptual spaces framework developed by Peter Gärdenfors (2000, 2014) for modelling the representation of lexical semantics, in conjunction with the concept of personae as discussed above. The modelling of *Mexican* differs from that of *dyke* and *lesbian* in significant ways. First, since *Mexican* does not appear to have a stable at-issue 'core,' the identification and distribution of personae is necessarily conceived of differently. Second, as can be expected, the quality dimensions used to locate personae in this space are different from those used for *dyke* and *lesbian*. Finally, this framework is used in conjunction with another proposal made by Burnett and combined into a single model, in which personae are understood to exist in conceptual space (Burnett 2019a), and the correct understanding of a speaker's distribution of personae is achieved through Social Meaning Games (Burnett 2019b).

3.2 Conceptual spaces and the personae of 'Mexican'

Gärdenfors' (2000, 2014) *conceptual spaces* framework represents meaning at a level between those of symbolic and associationist representation. In this framework, it is assumed that our conceptual representations have a meaningful geometrical structure, and that concepts can be located in conceptual space comprised of domains constructed of *quality dimensions*. The distances along a quality dimension represent the degree of similarity between two representations on that dimension, thereby allowing for the representation of concepts and of the relationships between them, which accounts for the relationships that exist between the objects represented, whether these objects exist in the world or only as mental entities. Quality

dimensions may be of a graded or discrete nature; both types allow for the meaningful representation of distances between objects in the space.

We can describe a conceptual space for the representations of the personae associated with the terms *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino*. To construct the space, we must determine what, from a phenomenal (psychological, speaker/hearer) point of view, are the salient aspects of the space. These include the quality dimensions that make up the space, the personae which exist in the space, and the lexical items used to communicate these personae. Further, we can identify different distributions of personae in the space, based in the differential ideologies of speakers.

In section 2, we identified the words that are used to discuss the personae that exist within this space: *Mexican*, on the one hand, and *Hispanic/Latino*, on the other. These are likely not the only words that would pick out objects represented in this domain, but they are a prominent pair for the meanings under discussion here. The term *Mexican* has been shown to have different meanings based on aspects of the linguistic context and the context of use in which it occurs – as a slur ($Mexican_S$), as a demonym ($Mexican_D$), and as a descriptor of heritage ($Mexican_H$). Along with this, we have the meanings communicated by *Hispanic/Latino*, which in some instances can be shown to be something of a non-slurring counterpart of $Mexican_S$. However, *Hispanic/Latino* is also available to those who use the term *Mexican* as a slur; I propose that this term, for the racist, picks out the same persona in their conceptual space. Given this, we have two terms, each with more than one use. We can associate these terms with four personae, which I will refer to as *referent personae* (personae$_\rho$), denoted by the letter ρ, or the personae held in mind by a speaker when using either the term *Mexican* or the term *Hispanic/Latino*. Personae will be denoted by curly brackets and a subscript, e.g. $\{M_S\}_\rho$, following the definition of a persona as a set of properties (see Burnett 2019b:432). Table 1 shows how these lexical items map to these personae$_\rho$.

Lexical Item	**Persona$_\rho$**			
Mexican	$\{M_S\}_\rho$			
		$\{M_D\}_\rho$		
			$\{M_H\}_\rho$	
Hispanic/Latino				$\{H/L\}_\rho$
	$\{M_S\}_\rho$			

Table 1. *Lexical items and their corresponding personae.*

When the term *Mexican* is used, then, it may be referring to one of three personae$_\rho$, corresponding to the three uses of the word described in section 2; similarly, the term(s) *Hispanic/Latino* can be used to refer to one of two personae$_\rho$. These personae$_\rho$ are defined in relation to quality dimensions in the conceptual space and are simplified stereotypes of people that exist in the world.

I propose the following quality dimensions for the space that is associated with the four personae$_\rho$ connected to the two terms under consideration: *family origin*, *personal origin*, *race*, and *(native) language*. The importance of these quality dimensions in differentiating among the distinct personae$_\rho$ held in conceptual space can be seen in the recent news reports regarding instances of the use of *Mexican* discussed in sections 1 and 2 above.

When used as a slur, *Mexican* picks out the persona $\{M_S\}_\rho$, which can be placed in the conceptual space based on five principal qualities. First, the personal origin of the target is ambiguous. This can be seen in the articles written about the use of the word in (1), here repeated as (14).

(14) The judge, who happens to be, we believe, Mexican, which is great, I think that's fine.

Manchester (n.d.), PBS (2016), Stracqualursi and Struyk (2017), Wolf (2018), and Wehner (2019) all point out that the target of the slur was born in Indiana, which suggests that these hearers wish to reproach the speaker for lumping the target together with those born in Mexico, and at the same time say something about the proper reference of the word *Mexican*.[8] The persona (stereotype, simplified imagined person) $\{M_S\}_\rho$ is ambiguous as to personal place of origin; for the model, this ambiguity will be represented as an assumption of being from 'somewhere in Latin America'.

The family origin of $\{M_S\}$ is taken to be some place south of the southern border of the United States, which is more or less the same as Latin America. This is evidenced, for example, in the treatment of a Puerto Rican man as 'Mexican' as discussed in section 2.6:

(15) Go back to Mexico if you want to keep speaking Spanish.... Go back to your Mexican country.

Here, we see no distinction made between Mexico and other countries in Latin America; the woman's use of the term *Mexican* in this instance suggests that Mexico is the only Spanish speaking country (or, perhaps that all Spanish-speaking people in the US come from Mexico) and that, as in the news chyron discussed in section 1, *Mexican* can be used to denote any country in Latin America. This, along with the lack of distinguishing a target's personal origin, gives

[8] The distinction these authors make between this speaker's use of *Mexican* and the use of the same term to felicitously discuss a person's heritage is an apparent inconsistency that can be explained by this model: this speaker is not taken to be employing the heritage use of the term; see section 3.3.

support to the idea that the representation $\{M_S\}_\rho$ is assumed to have a family origin which is (what is understood geographically to be) Latin America.[9]

This restaurant incident also provides evidence that 'Spanish-speaking' is an important characteristic of the persona associated with $\{M_S\}_\rho$. The use of the Spanish language and Mexico are closely associated in the ideology under discussion. This can be seen, for example, in remarks made about Spanish used in the US, as in (16), when a County Commissioner in Texas disparaged a judge from a nearby county for her bilingual updates in the wake of a chemical fire:

(16) She is a joke. English, this is not Mexico.

'Spanish-speaking' (without regard, apparently, for whether the person also speaks English) is an important aspect of the persona $\{M_S\}_\rho$; it is not, however, a sufficient or necessary condition. A telling story was related to the author by a Spanish immigrant to the United States: the man, who spoke English with a noticeably foreign accent, called his daughter's school to discuss attendance issues, and the man was met with a harsh reaction from the secretary, who asked condescendingly if he understood what she was saying. Upon arriving at the school, and the secretary discovering that he was fair-skinned, he received significantly improved treatment. This suggests that, when evidence of Spanish-speaking and of race come into conflict, race wins out.

[9] Note, however, that 'Latin America' as opposed to the US, has different meanings in the geographical understanding of the terms, and in this particular ideology. Whereas Puerto Rico may be seen as Latin American and part of the US in other ideologies, in the ideology of a person who uses *Mexican* as a slur, Puerto Rico seems to be specifically part of Latin America, and, in everyday use, *not* a territory of the United States.

Race, then, is the last quality dimension which is used for situating these personae$_\rho$ in the conceptual space, and I argue that it is the most important. When remarks are made that obviously use *Mexican* to derogate a target, the responses to its use invariably concern race (e.g. Associated Press 1997, Boyd 2011, Wolf 2018). Boyd (2011) reports on the offending congresswoman, who said she wasn't aware that *Mexican* was a slur, but who evidently learned through the incident that this was the case, and apologized for making racial comments about the governor.

These four dimensions – personal origin, family origin, language, and race – are the characteristics which differentiate among the personae$_\rho$ under consideration; they are the quality dimensions which make up the conceptual space in which $\{M_S\}_\rho$, $\{M_D\}_\rho$, $\{M_H\}_\rho$, and $\{H/L\}_\rho$ are arrayed, and which are represented in linguistic behaviour as the lexical items *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino*.

The final way in which these personae$_\rho$ are differentiated is on the quality of *valence*, the positive or negative attitudes that a speaker has toward the personae in their conceptual space (Greenwald et al. 2002, Burnett 2019a). The model produced here is rudimentary in this regard: the concept of positive or negative valence does not capture the strength or characteristics of the negative or positive attitude expressed regarding a persona. Hom (2008) recognizes the connection between the force of racial slurs and social institutions; Kennedy shows a similar sensitivity to the social correlates of a slur's meaning when he says that to ask if one slur is worse than others "draws one into the difficult and delicate matter of comparing oppressions, measuring collective injuries, prioritizing victim status" (1999:87). This is crucial to a full understanding of all slurs. Personae$_\rho$ can be seen as a way for the language user to package their experiences with social institutions, other individuals, and the social landscape and represent this package in their conceptual space, which makes this approach promising for investigating

the finer details of the status of personae$_\rho$ in this space.[10] For a more complete understanding of the power of slurs to derogate with the force they do, and the reasons slurs differ in this force, a closer evaluation of the concept of valence is promising.[11] Here, the valence of $\{M_S\}_\rho$ is taken to be negative, while the others are taken to be approximately neutral.

The four quality dimensions are shown in Figure 1, and are displayed separately for ease of exposition. Positive valence is shown in red, while (approximately) neutral valence is shown in blue.

As the diagrams in Figure 1 show, no two personae$_\rho$ are located in the same place, only differing in valence. This represents a departure from traditional analyses of slurs and from the model for *dyke* and *lesbian* given in Burnett (2019a). In the terms of traditional analyses, the personae do not occur in the same place because no persona is taken to be the 'neutral' counterpart of any other; that is, $\{M_S\}_\rho$ and $\{M_D\}_\rho$, for example, are *not* taken to differ only in the positive or negative attitude of an interlocutor toward them, but rather, they are taken to be distinct with regard to valence as well various quality dimensions. Unlike *lesbian* and *dyke*, where a derogatory use of *lesbian* could be shown to pick out the persona$_\rho$ which for other speakers is associated only with *dyke*, the separate personae$_\rho$ associated with the terms *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino* are found in different parts of conceptual space: speakers associate different qualities (beyond valence) with each persona$_\rho$.

[10] It also provides a connection to cognitive theories of how language is learned; for an impressive exemplar-driven usage-based constructivist approach, see Goldberg (2019).
[11] As an example, for *Mexican*, specifically, valence may be represented as a further quality dimension in conceptual space. Whether the analysis is amenable to this requires further investigation.

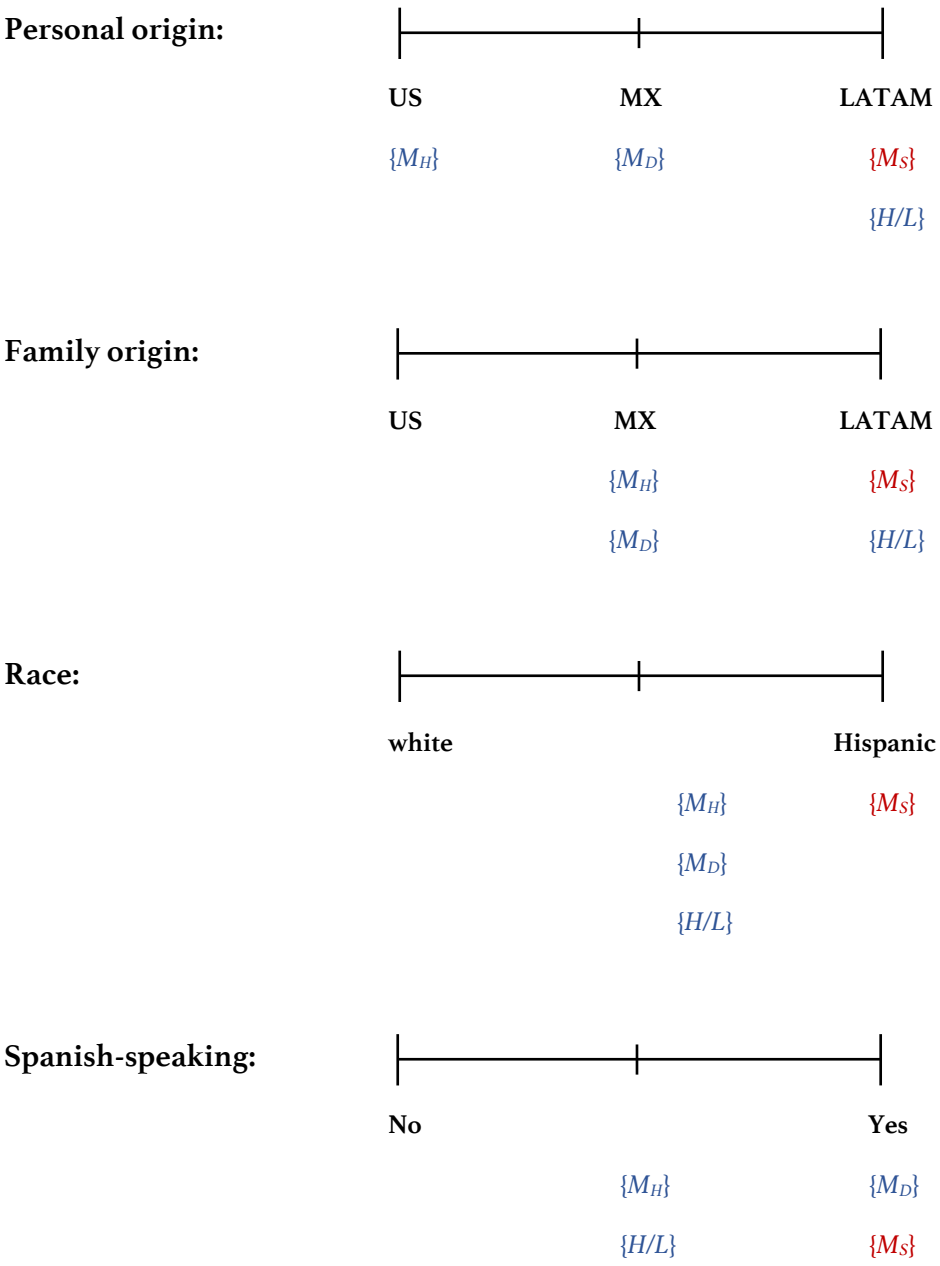


Figure 1. *Quality dimensions associated with the personae* $\{M_S\}_\rho$, $\{M_D\}_\rho$, $\{M_H\}_\rho$, *and* $\{H/L\}_\rho$.

The last consideration in understanding the architecture and status of representations in this conceptual space is that of the ideologies which are used in conjunction with the space. Personae$_\rho$ that exist in a conceptual space are contained within different *ideologies*. I propose

that an ideology corresponds, roughly, to the collection of all the personae$_\rho$ in active use by a speaker, the personae$_\rho$ which that speaker uses to talk about the world. These ideologies are all taken to use the same conceptual space to locate their personae (see Burnett 2019a). However, though an ideology doesn't contain a certain persona$_\rho$, the individual who operates with that ideology can still recognize references to that persona$_\rho$, and through a sort of negotiation, a persona$_\rho$ held in one space can be located by an interlocutor. These ideologies still require extensive systematization; here, we will employ this working definition.

I posit two general ideologies to account for the meaning and behaviour of the word *Mexican*: first is the racist ideology, so named because of the status of the single persona in this ideology, $\{M_S\}_\rho$, connected to uses of the words *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino* as racial slurs. The other ideology in question is the non-racist ideology, which contains three personae which differ, but share similarities with, $\{M_S\}_\rho$: $\{M_D\}_\rho$, $\{M_H\}_\rho$, and $\{H/L\}_\rho$. Every speaker found within a speech community will operate with one ideology; for our purposes here, every speaker of American English[12] is taken to use either one ideology or the other, racist or non-racist.[13]

In interpreting the meaning of an instance of *Mexican*, a listener, then, must first know which ideology the person they are dealing with is using. Once this ideology can be identified, the semantic and social meanings of the word can be assessed. This is the key to differential use and interpretation, especially interpretations which differ depending on the person who uses the word, independent of the context of use or even the intention of the speaker in that instance. For the listener to decide which ideology to assume on the part of the person they are interacting with, they take into account other aspects of their interlocutor, as well as aspects of

[12] Note that differences of competence in speaking a 'language' are important here, but will be left unanalysed. A community of practice (Lave and Wenger 1991) or social network (Milroy 1980) are almost certainly more accurate levels at which to approach linguistic competence and questions of ideologies and personae. However, the associations with *Mexican* are taken to be widespread enough in speakers of American English to take this group as the community of interest here.
[13] Other ideologies, though, probably exist. See section 4 for discussion on this point.

the message, and relationships that exist between certain ideologies and messages; they use various signals to interpret who their interlocutor is, making them more legible, as discussed in section 3.1 above. In the next section, these processes are brought together in *Social Meaning Games* (SMGs).

3.3 Persona assignation and meaning interpretation

Now that we have set up the conceptual space and overlaid the ideologies and their associated personae that are used in the population of American English speakers in the United States, we turn our attention to the last piece of the puzzle. In interaction, language users interpret the meaning of the word *Mexican* as it relates to the personae$_{\rho}$ that they reason to be held in mind by other speakers. Once a use of the word can be linked to a certain persona$_{\rho}$ in conceptual space, then a listener can react accordingly; the linking of a word with a persona$_{\rho}$ is tantamount to decoding the meaning – semantic as well as social – the word carries. This section concerns the ways in which listeners select an ideology to use in the interpretation of a token of the word *Mexican*.

First, we need to add another layer to our model, which is the layer of *assigned personae*. Every speaker holds either a racist or non-racist ideology, and cannot hold more than one ideology regarding this particular set of personae$_{\rho}$; the first step to figuring out which ideology is being employed by a speaker is what I will call *persona assignation*: the act of a listener deciding which persona a speaker should be interpreted as being.[14] This is the process by which a person decides that someone else is or is not racist; in doing so, a listener assigns that individual a persona – racist or non-racist – and interprets their speech through that expectation. This

[14] In everyday interaction, speakers and listeners act as though the people they interact with really *are* a certain persona, rather than the weaker assumption that they *represent* a certain persona.

persona must be *assigned* in that it is the listener that makes the decision, based on what information they gather about the speaker. But once it is assigned, the speaker is subject to the qualities associated with that persona. These assigned personae – $personae_{\alpha}$ – will be represented using the letter α – $\{R\}_{\alpha}$ for a racist persona, and $\{NR\}_{\alpha}$ for a non-racist persona. Table 2 provides an updated view of the concepts that have been introduced in this paper. The racist ideology is assumed of someone assigned a racist persona $\{R\}_{\alpha}$, and a non-racist ideology is assumed of someone assigned a non-racist persona $\{NR\}_{\alpha}$.

Lexical Item	**Persona$_{\rho}$**			
Mexican	$\{M_S\}_{\rho}$			
		$\{M_D\}_{\rho}$		
			$\{M_H\}_{\rho}$	
Hispanic/Latino				$\{H/L\}_{\rho}$
	$\{M_S\}_{\rho}$			
Persona$_{\alpha}$	$\{R\}_{\alpha}$	$\{NR\}_{\alpha}$		

Table 2. *Lexical items, referent personae, and assigned personae.*

Burnett (2019b) introduces a formal system which brings together sociolinguistic variation and game-theoretic pragmatics, specifically the Bayesian inference-based approach to pragmatic reasoning that is the foundation of the *Rational Speech Act* (RSA) framework (Frank and Goodman 2012, Goodman and Frank 2016), used to model pragmatic meaning interpretation, and also drawing on Lewis' (1969) signalling games. This system, called *Social Meaning Games* (SMGs), takes social variation in linguistic behaviour as an instance of interactive rational language use. This assumption is supported by Burnett's analysis of Kathryn Campbell-Kibler's (2006, 2007, 2008) and Rob Podesva and colleagues' (2015) work

regarding the perception of sociolinguistic variants and the interaction of variants and other social information about the speaker (Burnett 2017, 2019b). Regarding these studies, Burnett notes that the property attribution that will be triggered by a particular variant "often depends on which other properties the listener believes are held by the speaker" and that "listener prior beliefs concerning individual speakers appear to constrain sociolinguistic interpretation" (2017:253). SMGs explicate the process of persona assignation.

Burnett (2019b:429) characterizes SMGs as follows:

> [SMGs] are games of interaction between two agents: *S* (speaker/sender) and *L* (listener/receiver). *S* has a set of properties characterizing themselves they wish to communicate to *L* (their *type*). *S*'s action is to choose a message *m* to send *L*, and *L*'s action is to attribute a set of properties to *S* based on *m* and their prior beliefs about *S*, and, in doing so, update their beliefs.[15]

She further notes that:

> [C]ontrary to classic IBR/RSA models, something else will play an important role in calculating an agent's utility (and subsequent actions): *S* and *L*'s personal preferences in the context, which we will call their *values*.

[15] It's important to note that this framework does not assume that messaging and interpretation are consciously or intentionally carried out. This is important in the current context, as it is plausible to think that a person may not intentionally choose to provide information that would classify them, in the mind of their interlocutor, as racist; but this information may be communicated unconsciously. See discussion on this point in Campbell-Kibler (2008) and Eckert (2019b), as well as in Burnett (2019b).

The model is powerful enough to predict both linguistic production and interpretation. The specific component of the SMG framework that concerns us here is that of a listener's interpretation of an interlocutor's linguistic performance. Following work by Erving Goffman (1970), Burnett (2019b) assumes that, most of the time, we as listeners expect no strategy on the part of a speaker in the presentation of themselves in interaction; that is, listeners do not typically reason about a speaker's values (in the SMG model, used to denote their preferences in context), but rather, a listener will interpret linguistic behaviour based on the likelihood of a given variant being used to construct a persona$_\alpha$, and the listener's prior beliefs about the speaker's persona$_\alpha$. This assumption will be employed here as well; though we may sometimes know the nature of the value function of an interlocutor in situations containing the use of *Mexican*, the majority of interactions are likely interpreted primarily using the linguistic forms (or *message*) and a listener's prior beliefs regarding the type of person a speaker is. The listener interpretation rule is given in (17) (adapted from Burnett 2019b:441):

(17) $P_L(\pi|m) = \frac{Pr(\pi)\times P_S(m|\pi)}{\sum_{\pi'} Pr\,(\pi')\times P_S(m|\pi')}$

where $P_L(\pi|m)$ is the listener's probability that the speaker is best assigned a persona π[16], given the speaker's message m; $Pr(\pi)$ is the listener's prior beliefs regarding the probability of a persona π; $P_S(m|\pi)$ is the probability of the speaker employing message m in communicating a persona π; and π' is any persona that belongs to the set of personae that are in play, so that π is included in this set. (In our model, π' should be taken to mean 'any persona$_\alpha$ of the set of

[16] In its current state, the model assumes that personae are maximally consistent sets, such that a persona is the set of all properties that 'go together' (Burnett 2019b:430) and there are no non-maximal sets of properties which comprise a persona.

alternative personae$_\alpha$ relevant to the situation under consideration', this set consisting of $\{R\}_\alpha$ and $\{NR\}_\alpha$.) Informally, (17) represents the probability that a listener attaches to a given persona$_\alpha$ being the best choice to assign the speaker, given the message a speaker uses, based on the listener's prior beliefs about the likelihood of the speaker being of that persona$_\alpha$ and the probability that a speaker will use a certain message to communicate that same persona$_\alpha$, against the background of the sum of the products of the probabilities of each persona$_\alpha$ and the likelihood of a message given that persona$_\alpha$ for all personae$_\alpha$ under consideration. Importantly, a speaker's reasoning in selecting a message, given the persona$_\alpha$ they wish to convey, is captured in $P_S(m|\pi)$.

In the (simplified) social meaning game under consideration here, the message is the word *Mexican* or *Hispanic/Latino*, and the personae available to speakers and listeners in this situation consist of the *racist* ($\{R\}_\alpha$) and the *non-racist* ($\{NR\}_\alpha$). Two assumptions are made regarding the speaker's choice of a message given the persona they wish to communicate ($P_S(m|\pi)$). First, both terms, *Hispanic/Latino* and *Mexican*, are available for use by both racists and non-racists; that is, both words are taken to index either $\{R\}_\alpha$ or $\{NR\}_\alpha$. In practice, it may be that racists are more likely to use *Mexican* than *Hispanic/Latino* in referring to the one persona$_\rho$ in their ideology; this will have to be left to future work.

Second, and more fundamental, the listener's prior beliefs about the probability of a persona$_\alpha$ – $Pr(\pi)$ – are informed by *signals*: outward clues to a person's persona. The listener forms their prior beliefs regarding the probability of a persona$_\alpha$ in the situation based on signals; these signals correspond to the aspects of a person's appearance, body language, and "potentially every detail" (Mondada 2016) available to participants in an interaction. The various signals form the 'multimodal Gestalt' (Mondada 2014, Voigt et al. 2016) that a person is exhibiting in a given interactional moment, and while no resource type is given priority over

any other, here non-linguistic social cues are taken to inform the process of interpretation of linguistic behaviour.[17]

Here we limit ourselves to visual signals, though it is plausible that other sensory input may also inform our prior beliefs regarding personae (e.g. smell). The signals taken to be of importance to our model are race, politico-cultural alignment, and previous experience with the speaker. These three signals seem to be the principal cues used in interpreting the probability that someone will fit a certain $persona_{\alpha}$ when coming into an interaction. In the US, given the prominence of race in everyday life, it is central to our evaluation of others, and in this model, is a discrete dimension divided into white and non-white. Given the historical gap between the powerful white on one hand, and the powerless Hispanic, African American, Asian, Middle Eastern, and other ethnicities and cultures, on the other, it is reasonable to think that this distinction is the one that matters here. Politico-cultural alignment – defined here as separate from race – can be signalled by styles of dress (Eckert 2000), ways of moving (Mondada 2014, 2016), symbols such as tattoos, hairstyles, nail styles, bodily adornment, or anything else that might visually signal others as to one's identity. Lastly, prior experience with a individual has an important effect on the listener's probability distribution over $personae_{\alpha}$. Previous experience can occur on a personal level (a politically offensive relative, your university Latinx Studies professor) or through experience of a person in the public arena (such as is the case with politicians and celebrities); gossip or hearsay is a sort of extension of the former. A mathematical analysis of how signals may play into persona probability distributions will not

[17] In principle, this model could be extended to account for the interpretation of signals and/or signs expressed through other modalities, with linguistic behavior as a signal used for the initial informing of prior beliefs about the speaker. However, given that visual cues (at least in face-to-face interaction; over the telephone is a different story) typically precede linguistic signals, the process given here is a reasonable model of interaction.

be ventured here, but will be important to more fully formalizing the interpretation of meaning in interaction. Figure 2 shows the scales along which these signals are taken to fall.[18]

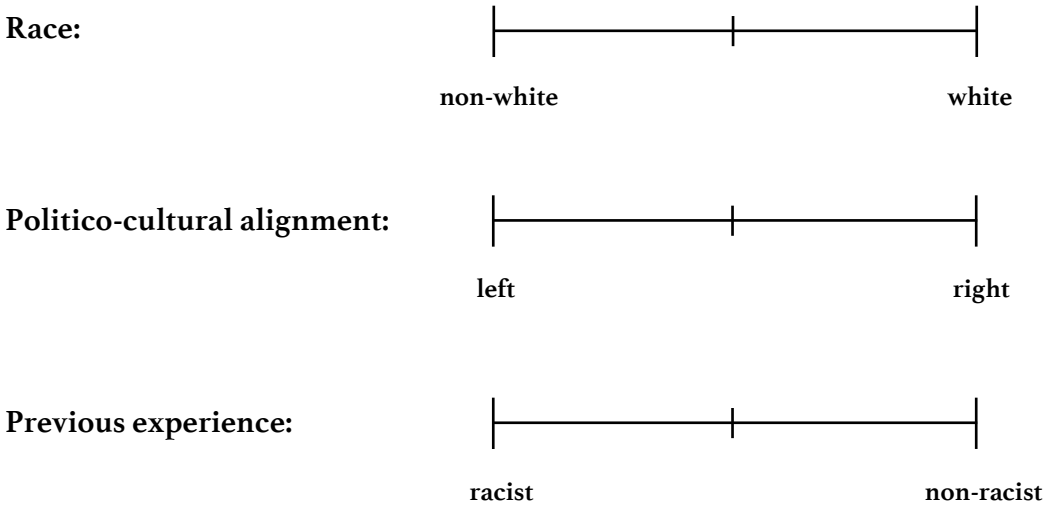


Figure 2. *Signal scales for the three types of signal used by a listener in determining* $Pr(\pi)$.

3.3 Explaining 'Mexican' with persona-based semantics and Social Meaning Games

Given the assigned personae $\{R\}_\alpha$ and $\{NR\}_\alpha$ which are assigned a speaker by a listener, the ideologies which are part of these assigned personae, the referent personae $\{M_S\}_\rho$, $\{M_D\}_\rho$, $\{M_H\}_\rho$, and $\{H/L\}_\rho$ held in those ideologies and referred to in communication, and the terms (messages) – *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino* – associated with the personae held in conceptual space, combined with SMGs as the process of persona assignation, we can investigate some instances of the use of the word.[19]

First, we look at the case of (1), repeated here as (18):

[18] Note that these scales are not comparable to those shown for the quality dimensions of the conceptual space under consideration, as shown in Figure 1.
[19] In these analyses, for simplicity, there is no cost associated with producing any variant. See Burnett (2019b) for more information on how cost fits into the SMG model.

(18) The judge, who happens to be, we believe, Mexican, which is great, I think that's fine.

The speaker in this case is a man who has been associated nationally with racism since his 2015 speech announcing his plan to run for US President (Ye Hee Lee 2015). Since then, the reputation has not fallen away. Whether voters and commentators feel positively or negatively about his language, it seems clear which persona_ρ he is referring to when he uses the word *Mexican*: $\{M_S\}_\rho$. This prior experience sets the stage whenever he speaks; his persona precedes him. This, combined with his race and political orientation (white, right), predicts that a listener's $Pr(\{R\}_\alpha)$ will be quite high, perhaps around 95%. Given this, the model predicts that he will be assigned the racist persona – and his uses of *Mexican* and *Hispanic/Latino* will be interpreted accordingly – well over 99% of the time. Considering the political division which seems to surround this figure, it is plausible to think that this is a reasonable estimate of the *expectations* of listeners – everyone has already made up their mind about him before he opens his mouth to speak. This means that any use of the message *Mexican* – i.e. where the context isn't taken as part of the message (see below), as is the case here – will result in his use being interpreted as racist virtually all of the time.

Next, we can take a hypothetical instance of a Hispanic woman who votes Democrat and with whom we have no prior experience. In interaction, our knowledge of another's politico-cultural alignment is not based on how they vote, of course; this information is not readily available. What is readily available are styles of dress, symbols worn on the body, such as tattoos or writing on clothing, and even hairstyles which may suggest that one is left- or right-leaning. On two of the scales given above, then, our speaker ranks in ways that would create a low $Pr(\{R\}_\alpha)$ on the part of the listener, and a high $Pr(\{NR\}_\alpha)$; on the third measure, she is

ambiguous, given that we have no previous experience with this person. Given these conditions, and a message which is not strongly associated with either $\{R\}_{\alpha}$ or $\{NR\}_{\alpha}$, we can expect, contrary to the last example, for our speaker's utterance of *Mexican* to be interpreted as non-racist – that is, as referring to either $\{M_D\}_{\rho}$ or $\{M_H\}_{\rho}$ – virtually all of the time.

At this point, the concept of 'message' in the model should be examined in more detail. We have been taking the message, m, to be the word *Mexican* alone; this works along the lines of the original model proposed in Burnett (2019b).[20] However, given cases such as those introduced in (2) and (9), repeated here as (19) and (20), we can ask if more of the utterance is taken as input for a listener's persona assignation process.

(19) [You're] carrying the Mexican's water on the fourth floor.

(20) You fucking Mexican idiot.

In these cases, *Mexican* is not acting alone, and the utterances seem to contain messages larger than a single word which are relevant to the interpretation of a racist or non-racist persona. In (19), *Mexican*, when used to indicate $\{M_D\}_{\rho}$ or $\{M_H\}_{\rho}$, would helpfully pick out a referent from among others, and lack a more relevant alternative. Assuming these criteria are not met – we can't know if there were more people meaningfully differentiated by race on the fourth floor, but it seems certain that there existed other alternatives, such as 'the woman' or 'the governor' – the listener takes the co-occurrence of *Mexican* and the words around it to be

[20] Note that Burnett's model takes into account only single sociolinguistic variants – she suggests that an important next step is to extend the model to account for sequences of messages (styles) rather than individual messages (variants). This is a tangential but important point to the discussion here: two plausible options are available for extending the model to capture multiple variants working in tandem in social meaning signaling and interpretation. The first is that some messages occurring together may be interpreted together as a single message, akin to the analysis of lexical items given here. The second is to introduce a sort of 'linking' mechanism into the model which can account for multiple instances of reasoning with content from within the same utterance. No stance is taken here on which would likely be a better approach – indeed, both may work together.

meaningful, and takes the whole utterance as a message for inferencing. In (20), the word *idiot* seems to call for, in one way or another, the word with which it co-occurs to contain a negative meaning.[21] The whole phrase is taken as the message in this case. The effect in both cases is similar to that of a sociolinguistic variant – in the same way that copula absence indexes African American identity (Rickford et al. 1992) and backer vowels indexed burnout identity in Belten High (Eckert 2000), so these utterances point to a racist identity. No analysis will be given here regarding the nature of the interpretation of which pieces of an utterance constitute a message, but understanding more in this domain will allow further detailing of the present model.

In calculating the listener's assignation of a persona to the speaker, we see that the listener's prior belief $Pr(\pi)$ in neither case calls for a categorical interpretation of the speaker's persona_α as $\{R\}_\alpha$. For the speaker of (19) – a non-white, left-aligned woman[22], and assuming no prior experience with the speaker, as would be the case in the media – $Pr(\{R\}_\alpha)$ is likely to be exceptionally low. But taking the whole utterance as the message, the probability of the speaker using that message m given that they are of persona $\{R\}_\alpha$ – $P_S(m|\{R\}_\alpha)$ – is equal to 1, giving us the result that $P_L(\{R\}_\alpha|m)$ is also 1. The outcome is the same in the case of (20): a white, politico-culturally ambiguous man with whom the listener has had no previous experience. Again, m in this case is such that the effect of $P_S(m|\{R\}_\alpha)$ overwhelms any value of $Pr(\{R\}_\alpha)$.

The above two examples show that this model cannot be taken to work in isolation, and the relationships among words in the message contribute to the listener's probability that a given persona is being represented, given that a more racially charged message will result in a

[21] My thanks to Toni Bassaganyas Bars for important discussion on this point.
[22] Note that (perceived) gender of the speaker may also be used in calculating this probability; this is an interesting route for future work.

higher probability that a racist persona should be assigned to the speaker. Further considerations for interaction within the message itself would be prosody and phonetic detail.[23]

4. Conclusion

This paper investigated the word *Mexican* as a slur, a demonym, and a heritage term, in connection with the words *Hispanic* and *Latino*. Traditional approaches to slurs, such as that of *expressivism*, were shown to be inadequate for addressing *Mexican*, due to its multiple at-issue and social meanings. I presented a model using conceptual spaces semantics, which can complement truth-conditional and symbolic approaches to linguistic meaning, and employing Social Meaning Games to explicate the interpretation of the meaning of *Mexican*. This model can account for such observed phenomena as social constraints on the use of this word and differential reactions based on speaker, such as that when a speaker who is known to be racist will always be interpreted as using the word accordingly. Extending this model to other slurs may be able to account for appropriation, differential force, non-derogatory, non-appropriated uses, and even uses of slurs in acting, where a different persona is understood to be the basis of interpretation.

Many tangential and forward routes have been suggested throughout; these have mainly fallen in the realms of interaction among different levels of language, such as prosody, phonetic detail, and information structure, and interactions within messages which are then fed into the model described here. It will also be necessary to look more closely at various parts of the model to refine some of the concepts employed here.

An especially fruitful path for future work would be investigation of other personae that fall in between or outside of the assigned personae given here. For example, there may exist the 'sort of racist' whose ideology may contain all four referent personae, and who may be more

[23] For examples of how phonetic detail can affect meaning interpretation, see Gahl (2008).

flexible with their use of each. Relatedly, the reasoning of learners of English as a second language should be evaluated – there may be, for example, a learner who understands the meanings of *Mexican* that are representative of the heritage and demonymic personae, but upon arriving in the United States for the first time, is confronted with a use of slurred *Mexican* regarding someone they know not to have any connection to Mexico. How does this speaker learn this new persona? How do children learning English natively learn which personae are represented in others' conceptual spaces? These and related questions are fertile ground for future work.

In extending this kind of modelling to still more slurs and non-slur lexical items, we can provide explanations of social rules around who can and cannot use a word, and gain insight into why it is that slurs are such potent weapons for denigration. This can also help us to account for uses of slurs which are seen as such by some, but not by others, and for appropriation of these derogative terms.

Lastly, further work in modelling sociolinguistic meaning, personae, and styles will allow for more specification in this model, and more broadly, it will allow us to find other ways in which social reasoning is integral to linguistic behaviour more generally. Here, it was suggested that the interpretation of semantic meaning is dependent, in some cases, upon social information about a speaker. Just as listeners have been shown to 'hear' a different word based solely on the persona information they receive about a speaker, so they may understand a different meaning using this information to inform their processing. More thorough investigation of the impact of the social on the rest of language use promises a more nuanced, comprehensive understanding of linguistic behaviour generally. Empirical testing of the model given here will be necessary to verify its usefulness in understanding slurring language.

The meanings of the word *Mexican* suggest that, in some cases, semantic meaning is underspecified, as has been recognized with social meaning attached to features of language (Moore 2012). This emphasizes the nature of a language system as socially constructed, and necessarily unstable. Whereas traditional approaches to meaning in language take their object to be a simplified, fixed system, the considerations discussed in this paper challenge us to expand on the idea that the "meaningfulness of sociolinguistic variation is… a design feature of language" (Eckert 2016), and ask to what extent semantic and pragmatic content also differ in meaningful ways among socially (self-)differentiated groups, and how this should inform our linguistic theories.

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